

C716

Business Communication

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A customer-service lead at a regional internet provider with a new logo is revising a notice about a system upgrade scheduled for 2 a.m. Sunday. The company has 80,000 subscribers. Which sentence best reflects the you-view?

- A. "You should know that we have a new logo."
- B. "You will be offline Sunday."
- C. "After Sunday's upgrade, you'll get faster speeds at no extra cost."
- D. "We are upgrading our systems to meet our network goals."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

An accounts manager at a family-owned supply company, founded in 1972, must tell a long-time client that the client's payment was sent to the wrong address and is now late. The manager wants to avoid sounding accusatory. Which sentence is best?

- A. "As a family business since 1972, we expect accuracy."
- B. "Passive voice is never acceptable in business writing, so: You erred."
- C. "You sent the payment to the wrong address."
- D. "The payment appears to have been sent to our former address."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A team lead wants to give clear credit in a thank-you email to an analyst who found a costly billing error. Which sentence is best?

- A. "Mistakes were made in billing."
- B. "The billing error was found."
- C. "Priya found the billing error that saved us \$40,000."
- D. "The team is always great at everything."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A sales coordinator at a fitness-equipment company with a warehouse in Ohio is drafting a promotional email for a new rowing machine. The draft opens with “Click here to buy now,” then lists features, then tells a story of a customer who lost 20 pounds. The machine comes in black and silver. How should the email be reordered?

- A. Open with the customer story, then features and benefits, and end with “Click here to buy now.”
- B. Lead with the color options.
- C. Cut the features and go straight from story to purchase link.
- D. Keep the order; lead with the call to action.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A persuasive memo ends with “Please approve the \$12,000 request by Friday.” Which AIDA step does that sentence serve?

- A. Interest.
- B. Desire.
- C. Action.
- D. Attention.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A former high school teacher with 12 years in the classroom, who runs marathons and speaks Spanish, is applying for a corporate training role. She has strong skills in curriculum design and presenting but no corporate job titles. Which résumé approach fits best?

- A. A combination résumé leading with training skills matched to the posting's keywords, followed by a brief work history.
- B. A strict chronological résumé focused on teaching titles.
- C. A résumé leading with marathons and Spanish.
- D. The same résumé she used for teaching jobs.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An accountant has eight years of steady, progressive experience at two firms and is applying for a senior accountant role. Which résumé format is usually best?

- A.** Any format, since format never matters.
- B.** A one-line summary with no work history.
- C.** Functional.
- D.** Chronological.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A vice president who travels often and prefers reports in PDF asks an operations analyst to review three warehouse locations and tell her which one the company should lease. She has already said she is open to any of them. What kind of report and pattern fit?

- A.** Informational report listing each site's facts, with no recommendation.
- B.** Analytical report, direct pattern: recommendation first, then support.
- C.** Analytical report, indirect pattern: analysis first, recommendation at the end.
- D.** A slide deck, since she travels.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A marketing analyst at a growing pet-food brand with offices in Denver and Austin wants to show how monthly online sales changed over the past 24 months for a board presentation. The board meets quarterly. Which visual fits best?

- A.** A pie chart of the 24 months.
- B.** A table only, since charts always oversimplify.
- C.** A bar chart comparing Denver and Austin.
- D.** A line chart.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A manager needs to show what share of this year's \$2 million budget goes to each of four departments. Which chart fits best?

- A.** A line chart.
- B.** A pie chart.
- C.** A scatter plot.
- D.** A line chart of the \$2 million.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A new product manager, who was a college debate champion, is preparing a 15-minute pitch. Her draft has 20 slides, each with two full paragraphs she plans to read aloud so nothing is missed. The room seats 40 people. What is the best advice?

- A.** Cut each slide to a few key points or a visual and explain the details aloud.
- B.** Add more slides to make the text smaller per slide.
- C.** Skip slides because she is a trained debater.
- D.** Keep the paragraphs so the audience can read along.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A compliance officer at a mid-sized credit union with seven branches writes: "At this point in time, due to the fact that the audit is in progress, we are unable to process requests of an urgent nature." The credit union was recently named a top workplace. Which revision is best?

- A.** "We cannot process requests."
- B.** "Because the audit is in progress, we cannot process urgent requests now."
- C.** "Currently, owing to the ongoing nature of the audit process, urgent requests cannot presently be processed."
- D.** "As a top workplace, we pause urgent requests during audits."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

A customer-service lead at a regional internet provider ~~with a new logo~~ is revising a notice about a system upgrade scheduled for 2 a.m. Sunday. ~~The company has 80,000 subscribers.~~ Which sentence best reflects the you-view?

Target word: best you-view sentence **Decides:** Focus on the reader's benefit.

A	Camouflage	Uses "you" but pushes an irrelevant detail.
B	Dropped element	Uses "you" but drops the benefit and the time frame.
C	Correct	Centers on what the reader gains.
D	Inverted operation	Writer-centered: focuses on the company's goals.

2. Answer D Concept 2

An accounts manager at a ~~family-owned~~ supply company, ~~founded in 1972~~, must tell a long-time client that the client's payment was sent to the wrong address and is now late. The manager wants to avoid sounding accusatory. Which sentence is best?

Target word: voice choice for a sensitive message **Decides:** Passive voice softens blame.

A	Camouflage	Leans on the company history and adds a scolding tone.
B	Absolute language	Passive voice has a valid use for sensitive messages.
C	Inverted operation	Active voice here pins blame on the reader.
D	Correct	Passive voice states the problem without blaming the reader.

3. Answer C Concept 2 · transfer

A team lead wants to give clear credit in a thank-you email to an analyst who found a costly billing error. Which sentence is best?

Target word: voice choice for credit **Decides:** Active voice makes the actor clear.

A	Adjacent category	A classic blame-avoiding passive, the wrong tool here.
B	Inverted operation	Passive voice hides who deserves the credit.
C	Correct	Active voice names who did it and gives direct credit.
D	Absolute language	Generic and does not credit the analyst.

4. Answer A Concept 3

A sales coordinator at a fitness-equipment company ~~with a warehouse in Ohio~~ is drafting a promotional email for a new rowing machine. The draft opens with "Click here to buy now," then lists features, then tells a story of a customer who lost 20 pounds. ~~The machine comes in black and silver.~~ How should the email be reordered?

Target word: correct persuasive order **Decides:** AIDA: attention, interest, desire, action.

A	Correct	Attention and interest first, desire through benefits, action last.
B	Camouflage	Colors are a minor detail, not an attention step.
C	Dropped element	Drops the interest and desire-building steps.
D	Inverted operation	Asking before earning attention reverses AIDA.

5. Answer C Concept 3 · transfer

A persuasive memo ends with “Please approve the \$12,000 request by Friday.” Which AIDA step does that sentence serve?

Target word: identify the step **Decides:** A specific request for a response.

A	Confusion set	Interest develops the reader's curiosity with details.
B	Adjacent category	Desire builds the case with benefits and evidence.
C	Correct	A clear request with a deadline is the action step.
D	Inverted operation	Attention comes first, not last.

6. Answer A Concept 4

A former high school teacher with 12 years in the classroom, ~~who runs marathons and speaks Spanish~~, is applying for a corporate training role. She has strong skills in curriculum design and presenting but no corporate job titles. Which résumé approach fits best?

Target word: résumé format **Decides:** Career change with transferable skills.

A	Correct	Highlights transferable skills while still showing history, and passes ATS keyword screens.
B	Adjacent category	Buries the transferable skills behind unrelated titles.
C	Camouflage	Interesting but not the core qualifications.
D	Dropped element	Drops tailoring to the target role.

7. Answer D Concept 4 · transfer

An accountant has eight years of steady, progressive experience at two firms and is applying for a senior accountant role. Which résumé format is usually best?

Target word: format for steady history **Decides:** Steady growth in one field.

A	Absolute language	Format affects how quickly readers see fit.
B	Dropped element	Drops the experience employers want to see.
C	Inverted operation	Functional suits gaps or career changes; it can make steady history look suspicious.
D	Correct	Shows a clear, progressive record in the same field.

8. Answer B Concept 5

A vice president ~~who travels often and prefers reports in PDF~~ asks an operations analyst to review three warehouse locations and tell her which one the company should lease. She has already said she is open to any of them. What kind of report and pattern fit?

Target word: report type and pattern **Decides:** She wants a recommendation and is receptive.

A	Dropped element	Drops the recommendation she asked for.
B	Correct	She asked for a recommendation and is open, so lead with it.
C	Adjacent category	Indirect order is for skeptical readers.
D	Camouflage	Her travel does not change the report type or pattern.

9. Answer D Concept 6

A marketing analyst at a growing pet-food brand ~~with offices in Denver and Austin~~ wants to show how monthly online sales changed over the past 24 months for a board presentation. ~~The board meets quarterly.~~ Which visual fits best?

Target word: chart choice **Decides:** Trend over time.

A	Confusion set	Pie charts show parts of one whole, not trends.
B	Absolute language	Tables show exact values; a trend is clearer in a line chart.
C	Camouflage	Answers the office detail; the data is monthly sales over time.
D	Correct	Line charts show change over time clearly.

10. Answer B Concept 6 · transfer

A manager needs to show what share of this year's \$2 million budget goes to each of four departments. Which chart fits best?

Target word: chart for parts of a whole **Decides:** Shares that sum to 100% of one total.

A	Inverted operation	Line charts show change over time; this is one year's split.
B	Correct	Pie charts show how a single whole divides.
C	Adjacent category	Scatter plots show relationships between two variables.
D	Wrong stem number	Plots the total, not the shares.

11. Answer A Concept 7

A new product manager, ~~who was a college debate champion~~, is preparing a 15-minute pitch. Her draft has 20 slides, each with two full paragraphs she plans to read aloud so nothing is missed. ~~The room seats 40 people.~~ What is the best advice?

Target word: slide design advice **Decides:** Slides should support, not replace, the speaker.

A	Correct	Minimal slides keep attention on the speaker's message.
B	Adjacent category	More slides of text do not fix the core problem.
C	Camouflage	Her background does not remove the value of good visuals.
D	Inverted operation	Reading dense slides splits attention and loses the audience.

12. Answer B Concept 8

A compliance officer at a mid-sized credit union ~~with seven branches~~ writes: "At this point in time, due to the fact that the audit is in progress, we are unable to process requests of an urgent nature." ~~The credit union was recently named a top workplace.~~ Which revision is best?

Target word: most concise revision **Decides:** Remove wordy phrases while keeping meaning.

A	Dropped element	Drops the reason and the word "urgent," changing the meaning.
B	Correct	Same meaning in plain, concise words.
C	Inverted operation	Adds wordiness and redundancy ("currently ... presently").
D	Camouflage	Adds an irrelevant detail.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	6	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	9	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	2	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	8	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	You-view (audience focus)	Effective business messages are written from the reader's point of view, stressing the reader's benefits and needs rather than the writer's.	Assuming that using the word "you" is enough, while the content still centers on the writer.	Sentences that start with "We" and describe the company's needs.
2	Active vs. passive voice	Use active voice for clear, direct statements and credit; use passive voice to soften bad news or avoid blaming the reader.	Believing passive voice is always wrong, or using active voice to assign blame.	A sentence that pins an error on the reader ("You failed to...").
3	AIDA for persuasive messages	Persuasive messages move in order: Attention, Interest, Desire, then Action.	Asking for action first, or skipping desire (evidence and benefits).	A sales or request message with its parts out of order.
4	Résumé formats	Chronological lists jobs newest first and suits steady experience in one field; functional groups skills and suits career changers or gaps but draws scrutiny; combination blends both. Tailor keywords to the posting for applicant tracking systems.	Using one generic résumé and format for every situation.	An applicant's work history pattern: steady, gapped, or changing fields.
5	Informational vs. analytical reports	Informational reports present facts without analysis; analytical reports analyze data and draw conclusions or recommendations. Use the direct pattern (recommendation first) for receptive readers and the indirect pattern for skeptical ones.	Calling any report with numbers analytical.	Whether the reader asked for data or for a recommendation.
6	Choosing the right chart	Line charts show trends over time; bar charts compare values across categories; pie charts show parts of a single whole that sum to 100%; tables give exact values.	Using a pie chart for change over time or for categories that do not form a whole.	The question the data answers: how it changed, how groups compare, or how a whole divides.
7	Slides support the speaker	Presentation slides should carry key points and visuals, with minimal text, while the speaker explains; reading dense slides aloud loses the audience.	Putting the full script on slides so nothing is missed.	Slides packed with paragraphs that the presenter reads word for word.
8	Concise, plain writing	Cut redundancies, wordy phrases, and jargon so each sentence carries one clear idea in as few words as it needs.	Equating longer, more formal wording with professionalism.	Phrases like "at this point in time" or "due to the fact that."

Course scope (public description): Business Communication is a survey course of communication skills needed in the business environment. Course content includes writing messages, reports, and résumés and delivering oral presentations. The course emphasizes communication processes, writing skills, message types, and presentation of data. The development of these skills is integrated with the use of technology.